

COMBAT MOVES

When there are no other options, when the sword slips free of its sheath, when the arrow is nocked, when the shield is brought to bear, make these moves.

ENTER THE FRAY

When you enter into combat, first set the rank of each of your foes.

- ♦ Troublesome foe: 3 progress per harm; inflicts 1 harm.
- ♦ Dangerous foe: 2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm.
- ♦ Formidable foe: 1 progress per harm; inflicts 3 harm.
- ♦ Extreme foe: 2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm.
- ♦ Epic foe: 1 tick per harm; inflicts 5 harm.

Then, roll to determine who is in control. If you are...

- ♦ Facing off against your foe: Roll +heart.
- ♦ Moving into position against an unaware foe, or striking without warning: Roll +shadow.
- ♦ Ambushed: Roll +wits.

On a strong hit, take +2 momentum. You have initiative.

On a weak hit, choose one.

- ♦ Bolster your position: Take +2 momentum.
- ♦ Prepare to act: Take initiative.

On a miss, combat begins with you at a disadvantage. Pay the Price. Your foe has initiative.

Make this move when combat is joined. Set up your progress tracks for your foes and roll to see who is initially in control. Then, play to see what happens.

If you are fighting with allies, each of you make your own move to Enter the Fray. The outcome determines your initial positioning and readiness. You and the other players then envision the scene and make moves as appropriate. If you have initiative, you are positioned to make proactive moves. If not, you make moves to defend against attacks or get into position. If you and your allies are fighting against common enemies, you share progress tracks and mark the harm you each inflict.

If you are fighting a group of troublesome or dangerous foes, you can combine them into a single progress track. This is called a pack. Managing your progress against a pack is easier than tracking them as individuals, and will make combat go a bit faster. For a small pack (about 3 to 5), increase the rank by one. For a large pack (about 6 to 10) increase the rank by two. If you are facing more than 10 troublesome or dangerous foes, group them into smaller packs and associated progress tracks as appropriate.

STRIKE

When you have initiative and attack in close quarters, roll +iron. When you have initiative and attack at range, roll +edge.

On a strong hit, inflict +1 harm. You retain initiative.

On a weak hit, inflict your harm and lose initiative.

On a miss, your attack fails and you must Pay the Price. Your foe has initiative.

Make this move when you have initiative and act to inflict harm on your foe. Narratively, this move might represent a focused moment in time—a single sweep of your axe or the flight of an arrow. Or, it can depict a flurry of attacks as you put your opponent on the defensive.

On a strong hit, you strike true. By default you inflict 2 harm if you are armed with a deadly weapon (such as a sword, axe, spear, or bow), and 1 harm if not. A strong hit on this move gives you an additional +1 harm (so, 3 harm with a deadly weapon). You may also have additional bonuses provided by assets.

Each point of harm you inflict is marked as progress on your foe's progress track, as appropriate to their rank. For example, each point of harm equals 2 ticks when fighting an extreme enemy, or 2 full progress boxes when fighting a dangerous enemy.

Narratively, a strong hit represents wounding your enemy or wearing them down. You have initiative and can make your next move. If this attack was intended as a decisive blow, you can attempt to End the Fight.

On a weak hit, you've done some damage but have overextended or your foe counters. You mark your harm, and your foe has initiative. What do they do next?

On a miss, you must Pay the Price. Your opponent strikes back and you Endure Harm. You lose position or advantage and suffer -momentum. You face a new or intensified danger. A companion or ally is put in harm's way. Your weapon is dropped or broken. Let the outcome flow out of the fiction, or roll on the Pay the Price table to see what happens.

CLASH

When your foe has initiative and you fight with them in close quarters, roll +iron. When you exchange a volley at range, or shoot at an advancing foe, roll +edge.

On a strong hit, inflict your harm and choose one. You have the initiative.

- ♦ You bolster your position: Take +1 momentum.
 - ♦ You find an opening: Inflict +1 harm.
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On a weak hit, inflict your harm, but then Pay the Price. Your foe has initiative.

On a miss, you are outmatched and must Pay the Price. Your foe has initiative.

When your foe has initiative and attacks, and you choose to fight back, make this move.

First, envision your action and the fiction of the exchange. Is this a focused, dramatic moment where you each seek an opening? Or is it a flurry of attacks and parries, advances and retreats? The outcome of the Clash determines if your foe presses their advantage, or if you take control of the fight.

On a strong hit, you inflict your harm and steal back initiative. On a weak hit, you manage to inflict harm, but your foe retains initiative and you must Pay the Price. The price might be that you Endure Harm as your foe counters. Or, you may face some other dramatic outcome as appropriate to the current situation and your foe's intent.

On a miss, you fail to inflict harm and must Pay the Price. This fight is turning against you.

As with the Strike move, each point of harm you inflict is marked on your foe's progress track, as appropriate to their rank.

If you aren't actively fighting back—you're just trying to avoid the attack or seeking cover—you should Face Danger instead of Clash. Using that move gives you more flexibility to bring a favored stat into play, and you suffer a relatively minor cost on a weak hit. Unfortunately, you also give up the opportunity to inflict harm on your foe.

If you ever respond to an attack by just taking the hit, that's not a move. The outcome isn't in much doubt. Pay the Price.

TURN THE TIDE

Once per fight, when you risk it all, you may steal initiative from your foe to make a move (not a progress move). When you do, add +1 and take +1 momentum on a hit.

If you fail to score a hit on that move, you must suffer a dire outcome. Pay the Price.

This move represents a last ditch effort to recover control of the fight. It is that moment when all seems lost, but the hero somehow rallies.

Turn the Tide lets you take initiative and make a move. The move can be whatever is appropriate under the circumstance—likely Strike or Secure an Advantage. Roll the move (add +1), and act on the results. If you've scored a hit, you may take an additional +1 momentum. Then, play to see what happens. Hopefully this bold action is a turning point for the fight.

Here's the catch: If you score a miss when you make your move, you should add extra severity to the consequences. You might face additional harm. Your weapon is broken. Your companion is grievously wounded. Consider the result of your failure and give it teeth. If in doubt, Ask the Oracle.

Narratively, this is a dramatic moment. Focus on it. Envision your character's action. You struggle to your feet and raise your sword, your eyes hardening with determination. You spur your mount into a desperate charge. You grab your opponent's blade in your bare hand. You pull the dagger from your boot and lunge. Or, perhaps you state your name, lament the killing of your father, and tell your foe to prepare for death.

END THE FIGHT

Progress Move

When you make a move to take decisive action, and score a strong hit, you may resolve the outcome of this fight. If you do, roll the challenge dice and compare to your progress. Momentum is ignored on this roll.

On a strong hit, this foe is no longer in the fight. They are killed, out of action, flee, or surrender as appropriate to the situation and your intent (Ask the Oracle if unsure).

On a weak hit, as above, but you must also choose one.

- ♦ It's worse than you thought: Endure Harm.
- ♦ You are overcome: Endure Stress.
- ♦ Your victory is short-lived: A new danger or foe appears, or an existing danger worsens.
- ♦ You suffer collateral damage: Something of value is lost or broken, or someone important must pay the cost.
- ♦ You'll pay for it: An objective falls out of reach.
- ♦ Others won't forget: You are marked for vengeance.

On a miss, you have lost this fight. Pay the Price.

End the Fight fulfills your previous moves and the progress you have made in this scene. This is the all-or-nothing moment where the fight is decided. Is your foe defeated? Is your victory a pyrrhic one, and tastes of ash? Does your foe suddenly turn your assumed advantage against you?

Since this is a progress move, you add the number of filled boxes on your progress track for this foe, whether it's a single enemy or a pack. This is your progress score. Only add fully filled boxes (those with four ticks). Then, roll your challenge dice, compare to your progress score, and resolve a strong hit, weak hit, or miss as normal. You may not burn momentum on this roll, and you are not affected by negative momentum.

You can End the Fight only after you score a strong hit on a preceding move. Your setup move can be any action, but should be framed as a decisive maneuver or response, intended to bring the fight to a close.

If you find yourself struggling against a tide of weak hits and misses, unable to make this move, consider building and then burning momentum to get back control. Use your favored stats and assets to improve your chances. However, keep in mind that End the Fight is not the only way to resolve a combat scene. You can flee. You can give up. You can negotiate or force a surrender. End the Fight represents the conclusion of a bloody, desperate combat, with both sides committed to see it through.

On a strong hit, envision how this foe is defeated. If you still face other foes (using separate progress tracks), you have initiative and the fight continues.

If you score a weak hit, your victory comes at a cost. Choose a listed outcome as appropriate to the circumstances. Then, consider the narrative implications of your choice and how it impacts what happens next.

On a miss, you should face a dramatic and dire consequence. Are you captured? Mortally wounded and left for dead? Is someone under your protection killed? Is an important objective or vow now lost to you? Make a choice as appropriate to the situation and the intent of your foe, or roll on the Pay the Price table and interpret the result as severe. Make it hurt.

When you and your allies are fighting against a common foe, you share a progress track. Any of you may attempt to End the Fight. If you then score a weak hit or miss, consider how your choice impacts the group and who suffers the cost as appropriate to the situation.

BATTLE

When you fight a battle, and it happens in a blur, envision your objective and roll. If you primarily...

- ♦ Fight at range, or using your speed and the terrain to your advantage: Roll +edge.
- ♦ Fight depending on your courage, allies, or companions: Roll +heart.
- ♦ Fight in close to overpower your opponents: Roll +iron.
- ♦ Fight using trickery to befuddle your opponents: Roll +shadow.
- ♦ Fight using careful tactics to outsmart your opponents: Roll +wits.

On a strong hit, you achieve your objective unconditionally. Take +2 momentum.

On a weak hit, you achieve your objective, but not without cost. Pay the Price.

On a miss, you are defeated and the objective is lost to you. Pay the Price.

This move is used as an alternative to a detailed combat scene. When you want to zoom out and resolve a fight in a single roll, make this move.

First, consider your objective. Are you trying to defeat your foes? Hold them off until reinforcements arrive? Defend a person or place? Reach a position? Envision the situation, your strategy, and what you intend to gain or avoid.

Then, roll and envision the outcome. A strong hit is unconditional success. Your foes are defeated, surrender, flee, or give up their objectives as appropriate to the situation and your goals for the fight.

A weak hit means you've achieved your overall objective, but at some cost. Since this is the resolution of an extended scene, the price you pay should be dramatic and meaningful. This can include suffering a significant amount of harm, failing to achieve a secondary goal, or encountering a new danger or complication. If in doubt, roll on the Pay the Price table, or you may pick from the weak hit options in the End the Fight move.

A miss on the Battle move should have dire ramifications on your character and your quest. This objective is lost to you. What does that mean? Are you captured? Gravely wounded? Have you failed to save a loved one? Is the settlement overrun by raiders? Must you Forsake Your Vow? Consider the situation and the intent of your foe, and Pay the Price. Make it hurt.

Use the Battle move as you like. If your story doesn't emphasize fighting, or you'd rather generally abstract combat encounters, you can use this move exclusively. You can also drop it into some portion of a larger scene. Perhaps you Battle to quickly deal with lesser foes, then handle the fight against their leader with standard combat moves. The mix of Battle moves and more detailed fight scenes can help you pace your gaming sessions and let you focus on what is interesting or important.

Battling Alongside Allies

When you and your allies fight together, only one of you makes the move. Others can make the Aid Your Ally move, using stats as detailed in Battle. Resolve those moves first, and then Battle.

On a strong hit, all of you benefit from the narrative success, but only the character making the move gains the momentum bonus. On a weak hit or miss, all of you suffer an outcome as appropriate to the situation. When in doubt, Ask the Oracle.

OTHER MOVES IN COMBAT

You won't rely solely on combat moves in a fight. Make other moves as appropriate to the situation, your intent, and the actions of your foes.

Face Danger : Combat Move

Make this move when you seek to avoid or overcome an obstacle in combat, or when you choose to focus on defense.

- ♦ You leap over a gully as you ride into battle. Face Danger +edge.

- ♦ The massive elder bear roars, spittle flying. Will you muster your courage against this terrifying beast?
Face Danger +heart.

- ♦ You bring up your shield as the raider presses her attack, standing your ground against the withering axe blows.
Face Danger +iron.

If this is a proactive move—you are overcoming an obstacle—make it when you have initiative. If this is a reactive move—you are trying to avoid an immediate threat—your foe likely has the initiative.

When would you Face Danger instead of Clash against an attack? If you are fighting back, that's probably Clash. If you focusing on defense, getting out of the way, ducking behind your shield, or taking cover, that's Face Danger. It's less risky, since you can leverage a favored stat and the penalty on a weak hit is relatively mild. Unlike Clash, you won't have an opportunity to inflict immediate harm on a hit, but a strong hit with Face Danger can put you in good position for a follow-up move.

You'll also likely Face Danger if your foe is trying to gain advantage through an action other than a direct attack. They move to the trees to get a shot at you from cover. Or they taunt you, trying to provoke you into a reckless response. Perhaps they shove at you, putting you off-balance for a follow-up attack. What do you do? Envision it, then make the move. If you fail to score a hit, you likely suffer a loss of momentum to represent this setback. Your foe has initiative and will try to press their advantage.

Face Danger might also be used to flee combat altogether. If you have a path and means to escape, make this move to see if you get away.

Finally, in cases where an enemy represents a minor obstacle, Face Danger can be used to avoid combat or as a means of resolving your action against a mundane foe. For example, you can Face Danger to sneak past an enemy or run away from a potential fight. If you are dealing with a minor foe from a position of clear advantage, such as firing an arrow from hiding, you can Face Danger to see what happens. In either case, a miss on this move might force you to Enter the Fray.

Secure an Advantage : Combat Move

This move is made in combat when you try to gain some leverage, improve your position, or setup another move. For example:

- ♦ You take careful aim before shooting. Secure an Advantage +wits.

- ♦ You perform a sly feint, trying to put your opponent off balance and create an opening. Secure an Advantage +shadow.

- ♦ You attempt to dishearten your foe with an intimidating roar as you charge. Secure an Advantage +iron.

Secure an Advantage can be used whenever you have initiative, or as a means of establishing a favorable position prior to the fight. Mechanically, it's a powerful move for building your momentum track toward a decisive action. Narratively, it's a great way to bring cinematic action into the scene.

When you want to Secure an Advantage, picture the situation. Consider the terrain, your weapons, your position, and your fighting style and approach. Consider your enemy, and their tactics and readiness. Where is there an opportunity? Envision your action, then make the move.

Compel : Combat Move

Compel can be used as a shortcut to ending a combat. You don't have to make the End the Fight move to surrender or negotiate a truce. End the Fight is the outcome of a desperate, probably bloody, skirmish. If you or your foe have other objectives, give Compel a try.

- ♦ You attempt to force your foe to surrender. Compel +iron.
- ♦ You try to surrender, reason or negotiate. Compel +heart.
- ♦ You trick your foe into giving up the fight. Compel +shadow.

Compel needs to be supported by the fiction. What is your foe's intent? How do they feel about you? Are you a hated enemy? A potential meal? What are they willing to risk to end you? Has the fight gone in their favor or against them? What leverage do you have? If there's no upside for them, you can't make this move. If you aren't sure, Ask the Oracle before you Compel.

Compel might be used proactively (when you have initiative) or reactively (when your foe has it) depending on the circumstances. Offering to surrender is a reactive response, and can be done when you don't have initiative. Attempting to Compel your foe to give up the fight is a proactive move made when you are in control.

Aid Your Ally : Combat Move

This move is an obvious choice when you want to bolster your ally's actions. Envision what you do to help them, make the Secure an Advantage move, and let them take the benefits of the outcome.

You should have initiative before you attempt to Aid Your Ally. On a strong hit, both of you then take or retain initiative. This is a huge advantage for your ally if they were having a difficult time making progress against their foe. On a weak hit or miss, you both lose initiative.

Suffer Moves : Combat Move

Make Suffer moves as appropriate when you face the outcome of your actions within a combat scene.

If you make a suffer move and score a strong hit, you may take or retain initiative—even if you scored a weak hit or miss on the preceding move. However, this opportunity does not overrule the fiction of the moment. If you are out of action and Face Death, you aren't likely to come springing back into the fight. If you do score a strong hit on a suffer move, consider what happens next and the moves you may make in the context of the situation.

Pay the Price : Combat Move

Being forced to make the Endure Harm move is the obvious result when you must Pay the Price in a fight, but there's much more that can happen in a dynamic combat situation. You lose your footing. You drop your weapon. Your shield is shattered. A goal is lost to you. A companion or ally is injured. You are put in a perilous position. A new threat reveals itself.

Mix it up. Make combat exciting and cinematic. Whatever happens, make the outcome one you wish you had avoided. If in doubt, roll on the Pay the Price table or Ask the Oracle.

Ask the Oracle : Combat Move

In solo and co-op play, you can Ask the Oracle about your foe's objectives, tactics, and specific actions. The oracle can also help determine the outcome of events or introduce new twists.

Use this move sparingly. For the most part, trust your instincts. Your actions trigger reactions. Who are you fighting? What do they want? What do they do next? Your first impulse is often the right one.

Chapter 6 includes the Combat Action oracle which you can use to prompt an NPC action or response in a fight. You can also leverage the description of your foe's tactics in chapter 5 to guide their behavior.

Be mindful of your surroundings and other characters. Ask questions. "Can I take cover here?", "Is the river shallow enough to cross?", "Do the villagers flee?" Consider your foe's actions and your opportunities in the context of the environment.

In guided play, the GM is your oracle. When you have questions about what happens next, look to them, or talk it out at the table. Your GM is free to use the Ask the Oracle move to answer questions.